Homebase: the thesis, the pressure test, and where the research landed

Everything we learned about agentic booking of local and home services, compiled as raw material for building the business thesis.

Compiled September 23, 2026 from the research thread of September 14-18, 2026. Companion document: "Mystery shop: 91 real booking attempts."
Evidence tags: **[VERIFIED]** = checked against a primary source **[INFERENCE]** = our analysis, not a fact **[SINGLE-SOURCE]** = one source, treat with care

1. The original thesis (your framing, Sep 14)

> "*Every human will soon have a personal agent to do stuff for them. Agents already have rails for Amazon / DoorDash / Uber / Booking.com-style commerce, but for local businesses - especially home services - even the agents need to go through the same painful route of calling different businesses. The most efficient way is a Stripe for locals.*"

The thesis in its working form:

- **Demand side:** proactive personal agents (Instinct, "town", Facebook's Muse, X's Grok, and expected OpenAI / Gemini / Anthropic versions) will need a connector - a platform, service, MCP or API - to book local services efficiently.
- **Supply side:** a decade of digitization by field-service-management (FSM) software (ServiceTitan, Housecall Pro, Jobber) already holds pricing, capacity, schedules and intake questions. AI front-desk startups (Avoca, Broccoli) and GTM layers (Probook / Topline Pro, RoboLine) are agentizing those businesses' front desks.
- **The company:** an agentic booking/execution platform between personal agents and local supply. Start one category in one city, orchestrate payments (visit charges, escrow), and build a reputation/data layer as the moat - with agent-generated per-job feedback building that moat roughly 10x faster than Angi / Thumbtack / TaskRabbit could.
- **Tailwind:** local-service discovery was concentrated on Google Maps; the aggregators are billion-dollar businesses but the lowest-NPS players for the supply side.

2. How the research was run

- **Two independent AI research rounds** - Claude Research (produced nothing usable; stalled twice at a connector handoff and is excluded from findings) and ChatGPT as an independent red team - plus primary-source web research by Instinct.
- **Primary source documents you pulled from Baker Library / AlphaSense:** ServiceTitan FY2026 10-K (413 pp) and Summer 2026 investor deck; three Angi earnings-call transcripts (Q4 2025, Q1 2026, Q2 2026); a Thumbtack expert call (Aug 7, 2025, former Head of Sales). AlphaSense Generative Grid outputs were treated as pointers, not evidence.
- **A live mystery shop:** 91 real booking paths across six home-services categories in Boston/Cambridge (full detail in the companion document).
- **An "own data" demand analysis:** what you actually ask your agent to book, and where booking struggles.
- **A live case study:** a real plumber booking hunt for 1 Western Ave, run the same evening.

3. What the pressure test changed - five findings that moved the position

3.1 Payments is not the wedge [VERIFIED]

Stripe + OpenAI + Meta already define ACP (agentic checkout: catalogs, delegated payment/auth, orders, webhooks) and Google AP2 handles agent authorization and accountability. A payments connector alone is a feature riding existing rails. The defensible layer is **execution**: intake ontology, capacity/quote truth, technician fit, fulfillment, exception handling, guarantees. Sources: docs.stripe.com/agentic-commerce/acp; cloud.google.com/blog/products/ai-machine-learning/announcing-agents-to-payments-ap2-protocol

3.2 ServiceTitan can legally choke a neutral network [VERIFIED from their API terms and 10-K/deck]

ServiceTitan's API surface genuinely includes capacity, arrival windows, technician shifts/skills/zones, pricebook, bookings, appointments, payments and reviews - the supply thesis is right about the data existing. But their API terms require "Authorized Application" status for multi-customer apps, bar acting on behalf of third parties and cross-customer aggregation/benchmarking, and restrict API data flowing into third-party AI output. They also sell their own booking-capable Virtual Agent, and front desks like Broccoli/Avoca already book directly into its dispatch board. Consequence: build on open/down-market FSMs (Jobber, Workiz, Housecall Pro) with first-party data, or sell tenant-isolated per-operator infrastructure - not a cross-supply marketplace on ServiceTitan's rails. Sources: developer.servicetitan.io/docs/apis; servicetitan.com/features/pro/virtual-agent; marketplace.servicetitan.com/partner/broccoli-ai

3.3 Angi is already running the thesis [VERIFIED from Q4'25-Q2'26 earnings transcripts]

Angi has launched a ChatGPT app, buys OpenAI ads near breakeven, is working on Amazon and other integrations, and is building a Homeowner Agent and AI Front Desk across 100k+ pros. "Agent demand meets digitized supply" is **not whitespace**. The opening is Angi's own leak: only ~2 of 10 homeowner jobs on Angi go to an Angi pro.

3.4 Availability must be probabilistic, not calendar slots [SINGLE-SOURCE: Thumbtack expert call, Aug 7 2025]

Thumbtack's mandatory Instant Booking failed because it modeled availability as free calendar slots - bookings went "into the ether," ignored drive time, job-duration uncertainty and economics, and churned pros. Their on-platform payments push also stalled on payout delays, which argues instant payout over escrow-first. Capacity has to be computed from SKU, technician skill, shifts, routing, duration uncertainty and margin rules.

3.5 "Publish an MCP and agents find you" is not a GTM [VERIFIED from platform docs]

Public agent distribution is reviewed and user-linked: Claude's directory requires a Team/Enterprise org, OAuth/security/tool annotations and review; ChatGPT's Apps SDK requires org identity verification and dashboard review before any directory discovery. The realistic path is B2B2agent platform deals plus a narrow consumer utility that earns installation. Sources: claude.com/docs/connectors/building/submission; developers.openai.com/apps-sdk/deploy/submission

Bypass risk after the first job further weakens a pure consumer booking network; the credible model is a provider-SaaS base + per-acquisition fee for new-customer discovery + guarantee fees. **[INFERENCE]**

4. The reframe: operator-side execution infrastructure

> **Working position going into the Mark Pincus pitch:** fund the investigation into an AI-native **dispatch-and-commitment layer** for multi-location field-service operators and the AI front desks serving them. Personal agents are later distribution. Primary KPI: completed, profitable jobs per eligible intent - not bookings, not listed pros. The scarce primitive is **permissioned probabilistic capacity**: an operator-authorized, executable commercial promise.

Strategy scoring (A/B/C matrix)

Strategy	Score	Read
A - Consumer marketplace ("Stripe for local")	47	Payments rail already exists; Angi owns the consumer endpoint race; bypass risk after first job.
B - Cross-FSM API aggregator	52	ServiceTitan's terms foreclose cross-customer aggregation; down-market FSMs only partially cover supply.
C - Operator infrastructure (recommended)	**78**	Permissioned probabilistic capacity + booking and recovery infrastructure for multi-location operators and AI front desks.

The product model

- **GetExecutableOptions**: the core object - given SKU, location, timing and constraints, return operator-authorized slots with real prices and terms, plus a state machine and exception taxonomy (hold, confirm, recover).
- **First falsification SKU:** functioning-system residential HVAC tune-up in DFW (an experimental design choice, explicitly not a sourced "best city" claim).

30-day falsification gates - continue only if all four hold

Gate	Threshold
Executable decisions	>90% of intents get an executable option
Price accuracy	>95% vs. what the operator actually charges
Human recovery	<5% dispatcher overturn / manual rescue
Commercial pull	3 paid pilots

Fail two of four and stop the formulation. The research also specified **15 exact interviews**: 5 AI front-desk vendors, 5 operators/rollups, 3 agent platforms, 2 FSMs.

5. The demand side: what the work established

5.1 The unit of value is a relationship-reset event, not an appointment [INFERENCE - your own sharpening, accepted into the work]

Value exists where the customer doesn't already have a provider: new city/home, provider quit or unavailable, dissatisfaction, urgent failure, one-off event, novel category, insurance change, or price comparison across 3-4 shops. Routine known-provider demand (salon regulars, standing cleaner) bypasses any platform by call/text. So service frequency is misleading; the metric is **frequency of provider-search resets**, and category ranking must weight **discovery share x volume x ticket**, not discovery share alone ("if the switch rate of HVAC repair is only 50% but the volume is 10x of movers, HVAC might be a better way to start").

5.2 The 12 evaluation lenses

1. Discovery/reset share
2. Frequency of reset moments (not service frequency)
3. Ticket x provider margin x monetizable conversion
4. Price opacity and number of comparisons/calls needed
5. Provider fragmentation
6. Urgency / time cost
7. Can scope/quality be represented before service?
8. Relationship lock-in and switching cost
9. Seasonality and local density
10. Regulation / liability / recovery cost
11. Official inventory / API / payment access
12. Operator ROI

5.3 Discovery-share hypotheses (to be tested, not market facts) [INFERENCE]

Category	Hypothesized new-provider share	Category	Hypothesized new-provider share
Movers	90-100%	Mobile detailing	40-70%
Locksmith	85-95%	Pet grooming	25-50%
Event makeup	80-95%	Tutors	20-45%
Photographers	75-90%	Routine vet	20-40%
Appliance repair	70-90%	Cleaning (steady state)	15-35%, but 70-90% at move/switch/onboarding
Handyman (new job)	60-80%	Salon (steady state)	10-30%
HVAC repair	50-75% (maintenance-plan demand much lower)		

These must be measured as new-to-provider bookings / total bookings, split by new-city, switch, urgent, event and repeat.

5.4 The volume equation and public anchors

> **Addressable discovery GMV = annual PAID service transactions x average ticket x new-provider/search share.** Better for wedge choice: completed addressable discovery transactions x monetizable gross profit per transaction. Raw switch share over-ranks rare categories; raw category GMV over-ranks routine/direct relationships.

- **Movers:** Census: 11.8% of Americans moved residence in 2024 **[VERIFIED]**; surveys (not official data) put professional-mover use at 22.7-38% and the average professional move near $3,020; ATA cites $32.2B industry economic impact (not booking GMV). Read: a real high-ticket, near-universal discovery moment; survives the volume adjustment. census.gov/topics/population/migration; trucking.org
- **HVAC:** commercial estimate of ~$17.9B US HVAC services market in 2025 (not an official booking count); EIA: nearly 90% of US households used AC in 2020. mordorintelligence.com; eia.gov
- **Doctor/clinic appointments** were head-to-headed as an alternative wedge and rejected as a first move: huge demand (Zocdoc: millions of monthly users, 250+ specialties, 18,000+ insurance plans, 18 years of EHR integrations), but the booking object is specialty + visit reason + insurance + referral + urgency, Zocdoc owns the ontology and mindshare, and PHI handling triggers HIPAA business-associate obligations. zocdoc.com/about/news; hhs.gov/hipaa

5.5 Demand is horizontal; execution stays vertical [INFERENCE from your own agent usage]

Your own history as a one-user qualitative sample: travel (flights, check-ins, boarding passes), campus/education (scarce office-hour slots, twice pushed back to your phone by Harvard Key/Duo), events (RSVPs), home services (the plumber), real-estate lottery applications, healthcare errands, warranty/RMA. The read: horizontal demand does **not** mean horizontal launch - ChatGPT/Claude/Instinct own the intent layer; execution stays vertical because inventory, authority, liability and recovery are vertical.

6. Evidence register

Claim	Status
ACP/AP2 exist and cover agentic checkout/payments	**VERIFIED** - Stripe and Google docs
ServiceTitan API breadth and restrictive terms; native Virtual Agent	**VERIFIED** - developer docs, 10-K, investor deck
Angi running the thesis (ChatGPT app, Homeowner Agent, AI Front Desk, ~2/10 leak)	**VERIFIED** - three earnings transcripts
Thumbtack Instant Booking failure mode; payout-delay stall	**SINGLE-SOURCE** - one expert call; corroborate before quoting externally
Agent app distribution requires org verification + review	**VERIFIED** - Anthropic and OpenAI docs
Mystery-shop results (2/91 confirmable, wedge ranking)	**VERIFIED** - our own logged study; see companion doc
Discovery-share percentages by category	**HYPOTHESES** - stated for testing, not measured
Category volume anchors (movers, HVAC)	**MIXED** - Census/EIA official; mover spend and HVAC market size are survey/commercial estimates
A/B/C scores (47/52/78), 12-lens framework, reframe itself	**OUR ANALYSIS**

7. Open questions and next steps (as left on Sep 18)

- **Your read on the wedge ranking** (cleaner-switch first, HVAC second) was never given - the mystery-shop summary landed without a reaction.
- **Proposed next experiment, unanswered:** 25 cleaner-switch + 25 HVAC intents with the throwaway-phone problem solved, then a kernel falsification test - does 70%+ of the request -> hold -> confirm state machine transfer across both categories?
- **The 2-page Mark Pincus memo:** the brief's recommendation is to pitch the dispatch-and-commitment-layer investigation, not the consumer company. Note: his address is believed to be mark@super.io (with a K; super.io is his incubator entity per Zynga SEC filings) - unverified, never confirmed by a delivered message.
- **Baker Library pulls still open:** Angi 2026 decks, and a Generative Grid across ServiceTitan / Angi / Thumbtack / Frontdoor / Jobber / Housecall Pro with source-quoted cells.
- **Provider response latency and aggressiveness** are unmeasured - no lead was ever submitted because every submit-ready form demanded a valid phone and no throwaway phone route existed.
- **TNT startup application (deadline Sep 27):** which venture you apply with - homebase or midsesh - is unstated.